milieu in which Rudyard Kipling was composing poems such as *The White Man's Burden*. The theory was based on the discovery of some linguistic affinities between European languages and Sanskrit. The date of 1500 BC was mostly arbitrary. It ignored the fact that both ancient texts and folk traditions have always maintained a much older timeline, but these were considered mythical and dismissed. To be fair, there were no known archaeological equivalents of Egyptian pyramids or Sumerian cities to prove an older history.

However, new discoveries would radically challenge this view in the early decades of the twentieth century. When the Lahore–Multan railway line was being built in the late nineteenth century, wagon-loads of bricks were removed from old mounds to be used as ballast. The bricks were of exceptionally good quality and most people assumed they were of relatively recent origin. In the winter of 1911–12, D.R. Bhandarkar of the Archaeological Survey of India decided to visit one of the sites in Sindh called Mohenjodaro (which literally means Mound of the Dead). He came away unimpressed. In his view, the bricks were of a 'modern type' and the locals had told him that they were from a town that had been abandoned just two hundred years earlier. He could not have been more wrong. Fortunately, in the 1920s, Rakhal Das Banerji and Sir John Marshall of the Archaeological Survey decided to revisit the site. Another team led by Daya Ram Sahni began to excavate another site called Harappa in Punjab (both these sites are now in Pakistan). They soon realized that mounds of bricks scattered along the Indus Valley were the remnants of a much older civilization, a contemporary of the Sumerians, the Minoans and the ancient Egyptians. It was named the Indus Valley or Harappan civilization.

Soon, more and more sites began to be discovered. The reason that the Harappan sites were ignored for so long is that they lack grand structures like the Pyramids of Giza that stare out at a visitor. There are large buildings that have been given names like 'granary', 'assembly hall', 'citadel' and 'college' but these designations are essentially arbitrary. We do not know what these buildings were really used for and, in most cases, we have little more than foundations and lower walls. There is nothing that